

The Song of Salt

A conflicted granddaughter, sent to remove her blind boatman grandfather from his beloved sea, instead discovers the untold story of his life's profound connection to it, healing old family wounds and finding her own sense of belonging by embracing his 'Lunara Gita' - the enduring song of the ocean.

1. INT. Ananya's Luxury Apartment – DAY

Characters: Ananya

ANANYA, mid-twenties, places a lavender macaron by a ceramic coffee cup on her luxury apartment's white marble counter. Sunlight floods the room, illuminating dust motes in the silent air.

She adjusts a glossy fashion magazine, then steps back, phone raised. Her lips curve into a practiced grin as she snaps multiple photos of the staged scene.

Her thumb scrolls. The grin vanishes. Her shoulders drop slightly as the phone lowers, leaving the macaron untouched, a vibrant speck in the quiet room.

2. INT. Ananya's Luxury Apartment – DAY

Characters: Ananya

Ananya's phone buzzes on the marble counter. She sees "Ma" on the screen, a flicker of annoyance crossing her face before she answers.

Bina (O.S.)

Hello, Ananya. Did you talk to Dad?

Ananya

Yes, Mom. I called. He's fine now.

Bina (O.S.)

Fine? When are you bringing him home?

How much longer do we have to wait?

Why does he want to stay by the sea?

Ananya pinches the bridge of her nose, her jaw tight.

Ananya

Mom, he doesn't want to come. He says...

Bina (O.S.)

What does he say? Always talking about the sea? What is there that he can't leave behind? You have to convince him to come back, no matter what. I can't wait much longer.

Ananya stares at the untouched macaron, her expression hardening. No immediate reply.

3. EXT. Fishing Village Shoreline – DAY

Characters: ANANYA, DUKHI, VILLAGER 1, VILLAGER 2

Ananya walks gingerly, her expensive sandals crunching on the shells embedded in the damp sand. Her gaze sweeps over the cluster of rough-hewn boats and thatched huts, her mouth a thin line of discomfort.

Nearby, two fishermen, VILLAGER 1 and VILLAGER 2, stand over a tangled heap of fishing net. Villager 1's voice is a sharp bark, his hand chopping the air towards Villager 2, who gestures defensively.

Dukhi appears from behind a stack of drying nets. He moves slowly, one hand gliding along a weather-beaten wooden staff. His face, etched with age, turns towards the rising voices.

DUKHI

Children, why all this shouting?

The fishermen's argument falters as Dukhi's presence registers. Their hands drop to their sides, and their postures soften.

VILLAGER 1

Sadhu! He was stealing fish from my net.

Dukhi's hand rises, a calm, steady motion. Villager 1's shoulders slump.

DUKHI

The Sea Mother doesn't steal anyone's things. Listen to her song.

The two men look at each other, then down at their feet. Their faces lose the tension, replaced by a quiet respect. Ananya lowers her smartphone, which she had been holding at her side. Her tight expression eases into one of quiet observation.

4. INT. Dukhi's Hut – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi

Ananya perches on a rough wooden bench, her eyes sweeping the humble hut. She notes bundled fishing nets hanging from the rafters and worn carvings on the walls. Dukhi reclines on a reed mat on the floor, his blind gaze directed towards the open doorway. A light breeze shifts a faded cotton curtain at the entrance.

Ananya

Grandpa, why don't you understand?
There's no point in staying here
anymore.

Dukhi

Mother Ananya, where would I go,
leaving this land? My life is right
here.

Ananya

You'll have all the conveniences in
the city. And you can live comfortably.

A gentle crinkle forms around Dukhi's eyes, softening the lines of his aged face.

Dukhi

Conveniences? Will happiness be found
there? Will the song of my sea be
heard in the city? If you have ears
open for the 'Song of Luna', you have
to stay right here.

Ananya's shoulders slump slightly. She touches the rough, splintered surface of the wooden bench, then recoils her hand subtly.

Ananya

But Grandpa...

Dukhi

No 'buts', child. I'm staying right
here.

5. INT. Dukhi's Hut – NIGHT

Characters: Ananya

Ananya sits hunched on the worn mat inside Dukhi's dimly lit hut. The only light in the room pulses from her phone screen, casting a stark, almost accusatory glow across her features. Her fingers fly across the keypad, a determined, almost angry energy in her movements. She scrolls through a gallery of images and short video clips she's captured: the vibrant fishing boats, children playing near the shore, but also worn-out nets, modest huts, and the sprawling, untouched coastline. She selects several, then types a caption with swift, precise jabs of her thumbs. The text on her screen speaks of "raw, untapped beauty" and "unrealized potential," hinting at the area's lack of modern infrastructure and development. She hits POST, the screen briefly flashing a confirmation.

6. INT. Corporate Office, Bhubaneswar – DAY

Characters: SANJAY

The glass wall of SANJAY's office overlooks the sprawling urban landscape of Bhubaneswar. He sits at an immaculately clean desk, a large, thin tablet resting on its surface.

His thumb scrolls methodically. He pauses on a vibrant series of photos showing rustic fishing huts, brightly colored boats, and untouched stretches of coastline. He reads the accompanying text with an almost surgical focus.

His eyes, initially dispassionate, widen fractionally as he taps the screen. A digital map expands, revealing a remote coastal village. He zooms in, isolating the cluster of homes near the water.

His index finger descends, pressing firmly against the glass, marking the exact location on the digital map. He leans back, a slow, predatory calculation hardening his gaze.

SANJAY

This is definitely made for a sure deal.

7. EXT. Village Shoreline – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi, DEVELOPER, VILLAGER

Two black SUVs kick up dust, braking hard on the shoreline. Three men in suits, clipboards in hand, step out.

One man immediately starts hammering bright orange stakes into the sand, marching towards the fishing boats.

DEVELOPER

This place is ours now! Get out, all of you!

An old VILLAGER steps forward, hands pleading. The developer shoves him aside. The stakes surround Dukhi's boat.

VILLAGER

But we've lived here for generations!

Dukhi emerges from his hut, his blind eyes turning towards the noise. A deep furrow appears on his brow. Ananya, frozen, witnesses the escalating aggression.

8. EXT. Village Shoreline – DAY

Characters: ANANYA, DEVELOPER, OLD VILLAGER, DUKHI

The DEVELOPER shoves the OLD VILLAGER again, harder this time. The old man loses his balance, falling to his knees in the soft sand, coughing into his hand.

DEVELOPER

Get out of here, old man! This place
is ours now. Go on, out!

Ananya watches the old man struggle to regain his footing, his face creased with fear. Her gaze snaps to Dukhi, who stands rigid, his face grim, his walking stick gripped tightly. Ananya's jaw tightens. Her shoulders square. She strides forward, placing herself squarely between the Developer and the fallen villager, her shadow falling over him.

ANANYA

Who are you people? Why are you
pushing this old man? Are you here to
throw your weight around?

The DEVELOPER freezes, his hammer mid-air. He slowly lowers it, turning his full attention to Ananya. He eyes her from head to toe, a dismissive smirk stretching his lips.

DEVELOPER

Hey girl, who are you anyway? This
isn't your business. Go on, get out of
here.

ANANYA

What business is it of yours who I am?
Why are you bothering them? This place
belongs to them, not you!

9. INT. Masi's Hut – NIGHT

Characters: ANANYA, MASI

A small oil lamp flickers on a low wooden shelf, casting wavering light on the mud walls of Masi's hut. Ananya sits cross-legged on a woven mat, her expression drawn.

Masi meticulously buffs a cowrie shell with a small, damp cloth, her fingers tracing its ridges. She doesn't look at Ananya.

MASI

Your mother can't stay here, my child.

Masi pauses, holding the polished shell up to the lamp, inspecting its gleam. Her gaze then drifts to Ananya, soft and knowing.

MASI

She's terribly afraid of the sea.

ANANYA

I know. But why so afraid? Since she was little, they always told her the sea swallows everything.

Masi gently places the cowrie with a small pile of other polished shells. She turns her body fully towards Ananya, her eyes distant, reliving an old memory before her focus sharpens. Her voice drops to a near whisper.

MASI

Many years ago... before you were born... your father had an older brother. He was very dear to him.

ANANYA

My uncle?

MASI

Yes. He used to come here sometimes... one day, a terrible storm hit. It destroyed everything.

Masi's eyes fix on the small, open window, where the low rumble of the distant sea is just audible.

MASI

No one could find him.

Ananya freezes, her gaze locked on Masi. The hand resting on her knee slowly clenches into a tight fist.

ANANYA

The sea... took him?

Masi gives one slow, solemn nod. The lamplight catches a glint of moisture in her eyes.

MASI

Ever since that day, your mother has been broken. For her, the sea means

only fear... and the pain of loss.
That's why she ran away from this
place.

Ananya slowly turns her head, looking past the open doorway of the
hut, towards the constant, deep hum of the ocean in the quiet night.

10. EXT. Village Well and Fishing Grounds – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Villager, Woman, Children

Ananya walks towards the familiar fishing grounds. Her steps falter as she spots a crude, barbed-wire FENCE stretching across the sandy path, blocking access to the sea. Her eyes widen in disbelief.

A VILLAGER stands before it, his fist banging hard against a fence post. His face is tight with frustration.

VILLAGER

They've put up a fence around our
land! How are we supposed to go
fishing now?

Ananya's jaw tightens. She stares at the sharp wires, a flicker of cold anger in her gaze. A distressed CRY from nearby pulls her attention away. She spins around and rushes towards the village well.

A WOMAN struggles with the hand pump, its metal handle bent and broken. Children huddle nearby, whimpering softly, clutching empty pots.

WOMAN

There's no water! Everything has dried
up. How can they be so cruel?

Ananya looks from the broken pump to the terrified children, then back towards the fenced-off shore. Her knuckles whiten as her hands clench into fists at her sides. A fierce resolve hardens her features, replacing her earlier annoyance.

ANANYA

Can they really stoop this low?

11. EXT. Sacred Fishing Spot – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi, Developer

Ananya and Dukhi approach a small, secluded cove. The familiar cluster of smooth, sea-worn stones, where Dukhi always offered his prayers, is now scattered across the sand. A rough, wooden signpost lies splintered.

Two DEVELOPERS finish hammering a printed NOTICE onto a newly erected, crude wooden stake. They glance at Dukhi and Ananya, a smirk playing on their lips, then turn and walk away, their footsteps crunching on seashells.

Dukhi's hand trembles as he reaches out towards the scattered stones. His head droops, his shoulders slumping forward.

DUKHI

What have they done? This place... the
memory of my father and grandfather...
they've destroyed it all.

Ananya's gaze falls upon the harsh, official print on the eviction notice. Her shoulders slump forward. Her breath catches, a visible tightness in her jaw. She stares, unblinking, at the document.

ANANYA

What have I done?

She crushes the notice in her hand, the paper crumpling loudly.

ANANYA

It feels like everything is over.

12. EXT. Desecrated Spot – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi

Ananya watches Dukhi. The crumpled eviction notice still held tight in her hand. Dukhi slowly raises his head, his sightless eyes appearing to trace the scattered debris of the desecrated spot. He bends, his old knees cracking faintly as he lowers himself to the ground.

He fumbles at his waist, untying a small, worn cloth pouch. From within, he carefully pulls out a perfectly spiral-patterned seashell, smooth and polished by the sea. He holds it gently in his open palm, his thumb slowly stroking its ridges.

He places the seashell onto a flat stone, the only one remaining unbroken amidst the splintered wood and scattered rocks. He bows his head slightly, a private moment.

DUKHI

We'll stay right here. As long as
we're around, you'll be too.

Ananya's eyes are fixed on the small, vibrant shell. The ocean waves crash softly in the background, a constant, rhythmic sound. Her shoulders, previously slumped, slowly begin to rise, pulling back with a deliberate effort.

Her jaw muscles clench, a small knot forming at the corner of her mouth. Her hands, still holding the crushed notice, curl into tight fists at her sides. She inhales deeply, her chest visibly expanding.

Her chin rises. Her gaze hardens, sweeping from the shell, past Dukhi, and out towards the distant horizon. She turns abruptly, taking a firm, deliberate step onto the path out of the cove.

13. INT. Ananya's Temporary Village Workspace – NIGHT

Characters: ANANYA

A battery-operated lantern casts a warm, flickering glow, illuminating a rough, upturned wooden crate. This improvised workstation supports ANANYA's open laptop. A spiral-bound notebook, filled with quick Odia script and sketches, lies beside it, pushed among empty tea cups and tangled charging cables. The soft hum of the laptop fan fills the quiet hut as her fingers fly across the keyboard, eyes glued to the screen.

The laptop screen shows a video editing timeline. She drags and drops digital clips: a jarring segment of developers' bulldozers scarring the shore, a quick zoom on the crumpled eviction notice, and a poignant, slow-motion shot of Dukhi's hand gently placing the seashell on the sand. She adjusts a small, clip-on microphone attached to her collar, then speaks, her voice clear and resonant, over the recorded visuals.

ANANYA (O.S.)

This land, this water, it's been ours
since our fathers and grandfathers.
This isn't just a place to catch fish,
it's our life. What would they
understand about the songs of our
fishermen?

She taps the spacebar. The short, impactful sequence plays back. A quiet, determined focus holds her gaze as the render progress bar swiftly fills, the laptop's hum a steady companion.

14. EXT. Various Locations (Bhubaneswar/Online) – DAY

Characters: Ananya, NEWS ANCHOR

A HAND-HELD PHONE screen glows. Ananya's post, a collage of the desecrated shoreline and Dukhi's quiet protest, displays hundreds of likes, shares, and a stream of supportive comments in Odia. A finger scrolls down, revealing more engagement.

A LAPTOP screen in a sparsely decorated room shows a news aggregator. A headline flashes: "Village Victim of Corporate Greed: Campaign to Save Coastal Area". Below it, a thumbnail of Ananya's video plays on a loop, showing the developers' bulldozer.

On a TELEVISION in a busy tea stall, a NEWS ANCHOR speaks with urgency, graphics of the fishing village overlaid on the screen.

NEWS ANCHOR

These villagers have united to save their ancestral land and sea. This campaign is going viral on social media.

15. EXT. Village Square – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi, Masi, Villager 1

A large gathering of villagers stands close in the open village square, forming a semicircle. Ananya perches on an overturned, weathered fishing boat, using it as a temporary platform. Dukhi and Masi are visible among the attentive faces in the crowd. Ananya gestures with firm, deliberate movements as she outlines her strategy.

ANANYA

We will save our village, our sea. We will protest peacefully. No one will resort to violence.

ANANYA

Our message must be clear. This land, this sea belongs to us. It has been passed down from our ancestors.

Villagers murmur their agreement, their expressions shifting from frustration to a shared sense of resolve.

VILLAGER 1

We are ready, Ma. We will do whatever it takes.

MASI

No one can silence the songs of our fisherwomen!

ANANYA

You're right, Masi. This is our strength.

Dukhi tilts his head, a gentle, knowing expression settling on his features as he listens.

16. EXT. Village Square – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Bina, Dukhi, Masi, Villagers

Ananya stands on the overturned boat, her voice clear, carrying across the village square. Villagers listen, some nodding, others exchanging determined glances.

Ananya

This soil, this water is our identity.
No one can break our courage.

A dusty yellow taxi, starkly out of place, stops at the edge of the square. Bina steps out, dressed in crisp city clothes, her posture rigid. She eyes the crowd, then spots Ananya on the boat. She sees Dukhi and Masi among the attentive faces.

Ananya

The song of our blood will never stop.
It is the strength of our ancestors.

A deep crease forms between Bina's brows. Her gaze softens, yet holds a new intensity. She watches Ananya's unwavering conviction, the way the community rallies around her. Bina's rigid shoulders slowly relax.

17. INT. Village Meeting Hall – NIGHT

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi, Bina, Lead Developer, Villagers

The air in the village meeting hall is thick with tension. VILLAGERS huddle on the floor, their faces etched with worry. A LEAD DEVELOPER, flanked by two others, stands by a long table, holding up a stack of legal documents. Dukhi sits quietly, his sightless eyes fixed forward. Bina stands near the back, her gaze fixed on Ananya.

LEAD DEVELOPER

This is a legal notice. You have 24 hours. After that, this place is ours.

A collective gasp ripples through the villagers. Some mothers pull their children closer. Ananya walks forward, taking the document from the developer. She scans the legalese quickly, her jaw tightening. Her eyes meet Dukhi's, then sweep across the frightened faces of her community. She holds the document in a firm grip, then slowly tears it in half.

ANANYA

24 hours? By that count, not even a minute.

She lets the pieces flutter to the ground. Dukhi offers a small, knowing smile.

ANANYA

This land is ours. We will live here.

18. EXT. Village Shoreline / Protest Site – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Bina, Dukhi, Masi, Lead Developer, Legal Counsel, Villagers, Reporters, Cameramen

The shoreline pulses with hundreds of villagers, a solid wall of people standing firm behind a thin rope stretched taut along the sand. This rope marks the developers' demarcation line. Hand-painted banners, weathered by sun and salt, flap rhythmically in the strong sea breeze, proclaiming " , " (Our land, our life) and " " (Our rights are ours). REPORTERS and CAMERAMEN from various news outlets jostle for position, their lenses and microphones glinting under the mid-morning sun, capturing every angle of the organized resistance. Ananya moves through the dense crowd, a confident nod for one villager, a quick, reassuring glance for another, her presence a quiet strength. Bina stands near Masi, her arm linked through her mother's, her gaze fixed on Ananya, a slight tremor in her posture revealing a hidden anxiety. Dukhi sits cross-legged on the sand, his hands resting open, palms down, at his sides. His face, weathered by years of sun and sea, is serene, tilted slightly towards the incoming tide, absorbing its rhythm.

The LEAD DEVELOPER, a sharply dressed man in a sweat-stained suit, pushes through the cluster of reporters with his two harried associates. Their expensive clothes look out of place against the sandy backdrop. They exude an air of utter defeat, their steps heavy.

An older, distinguished LEGAL COUNSEL, representing the villagers, steps forward, holding up a thick, well-worn file.

LEGAL COUNSEL

Mr. Das, we have all the proof. Your company will face many lawsuits. Even internationally.

The Lead Developer's shoulders pull back, a muscle twitching visibly in his cheek. Several microphones are thrust closer to his face, invading his personal space. He glances desperately at his associates, who avoid his eyes, looking at their shoes. His shoulders slump. He takes a deep, ragged breath, the sound audible through the microphones.

LEAD DEVELOPER

Alright. Listen... we're withdrawing completely from this project.

A sudden, heavy SILENCE falls across the entire shoreline. The only sound is the gentle lapping of the waves against the sand. Then, a collective, stunned murmur rises from the villagers. Faces turn to each other, disbelief dawning into comprehension. A young woman near the front gasps audibly, her hand flying to her mouth. The Lead Developer clears his throat, his voice regaining a sliver of authority, though it cracks slightly.

LEAD DEVELOPER

We have no claims. You people are safe here. And... this is the final decision.

He pushes past the reporters, almost running now, his associates scrambling to keep up, their suits flapping. As they disappear into the distance, a thunderous ROAR of triumph erupts from the villagers. CHEERS, shouts of joy, and heartfelt CRIES fill the air. People embrace tightly, tears streaming down their faces. Hands are thrown upwards in gratitude towards the sky. The media immediately pivots, their cameras swinging back to Ananya and the Legal Counsel, hungry for the next shot.

Ananya's eyes meet Dukhi's. Dukhi slowly turns his head towards Ananya, a profound calm in his blind eyes. He inclines his head once, a silent, weighty acknowledgment passing between them. Bina watches her daughter, her usual anxious expression replaced by a look of profound relief and quiet pride, a single tear tracing a path down her cheek.

ANANYA

This land is ours. And we will stay
united.

The piercing, resonant BLAST of conch shells echoes across the shoreline, joining the joyful din of the crowd. The sea, in its vastness, seems to answer with a deeper, more triumphant roar, embracing the celebration.

CUT TO:

19. EXT. Revitalized Shoreline – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Children

The shoreline is pristine, the sand smoothed clean by the tide, shimmering under the sun. Small waves gently lap the shore. A group of CHILDREN chase small crabs at the water's edge. Their joyful laughter carries on the gentle breeze. Bare feet kick up sprays of water.

Ananya stands a little apart from the children, her figure framed against the expanse of the ocean. Her gaze follows their play, then drifts across the tranquil sea. A gentle smile spreads across her lips.

She takes a deep, slow breath, her chest rising and falling evenly. She closes her eyes for a moment, her face tilting towards the sun. Her shoulders visibly relax.

Ananya lowers her hand and gently touches the wet sand with her fingertips, tracing a shallow line before lifting them again. Her eyes remain on the horizon.

Ananya

This is my 'Luna's Song'... my home.
My everything.

20. EXT. Dukhi's Hut Porch – DAY

Characters: Dukhi, Bina, Ananya

The porch of Dukhi's hut is bathed in soft afternoon light. Dukhi sits on his usual wooden stool, facing the sea. Ananya stands a few steps away, looking out at the water. Bina approaches Dukhi, her steps slow. She stops behind him.

Bina

Father... I didn't understand you.
Forgive me.

Bina's shoulders slump slightly. She takes a breath.

Bina

Afraid of the sea, I forgot the melody
of this song. Now I've returned.

Bina reaches out, gently placing a hand on Dukhi's shoulder. Dukhi's head turns slowly in her direction, his sightless eyes unfocused. Bina then steps forward and wraps her arms around him, resting her head on his shoulder. Dukhi's gnarled hands rise, slowly patting her back.

Dukhi

I knew you'd come back someday, my
daughter. The song of the moon is in
your blood.

Bina

I will protect it, Father. We'll all
protect it together.

Bina holds him tighter. Ananya watches them, a quiet smile on her lips, as her mother and grandfather hold each other.

21. EXT. Village Festival – DAY

Characters: Ananya, Dukhi, Bina, YOUNG MAN, YOUNG WOMAN, VILLAGERS

Bright orange and blue fabric banners billow between palm trees in the village square. Children dart through the festive crowd, their shouts rising above the rhythmic DHOL. Women ladle steaming pitha onto banana leaves, the sweet scent of jaggery mingling with the sea air.

Ananya stands near a newly erected wooden signboard, its fresh paint still gleaming. She gestures towards it, her voice calm and clear, as she addresses a small group of younger villagers gathered around her. She points out carved symbols and new text etched into the wood.

Under the banyan tree's shade, Dukhi leans back on a woven mat, his lips curved in a subtle, pleased smile. Bina settles next to him, her fingers lightly touching his forearm. Her gaze tracks Ananya, a soft pride softening her features.

A YOUNG MAN, younger than Ananya, steps forward from the group.

YOUNG MAN

Apa, we all have big dreams for our village. What's our new plan?

ANANYA

Look, this new board shows the first step of our 'Sagar Saathi' project. Next week, we'll start planting coastal forests along the shore. This will protect our fishing grounds and save our 'Luna's Song'.

A young woman, Ananya's contemporary, steps forward, her posture eager.

YOUNG WOMAN

We are all with you, Apa. I'll bring my children too!

Ananya's smile warms her expression. She rotates towards the signboard, her palm brushing the carved symbols. Her eyes fix on the distant ocean, holding a silent promise.